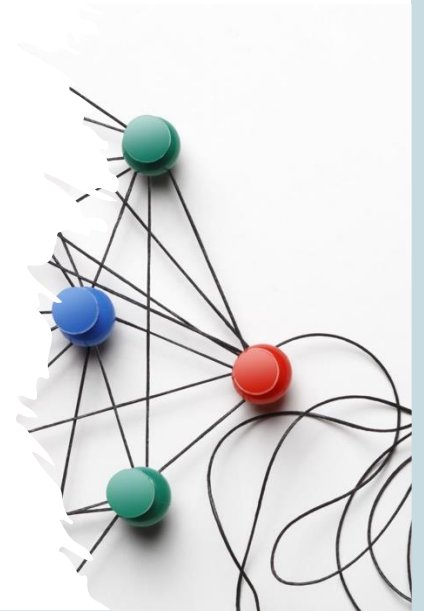


The Weak Shall Govern? Network Explanations for Non-Binding IGO Effectiveness: Evidence from APEC

Jeffery Shih-Chieh Wang

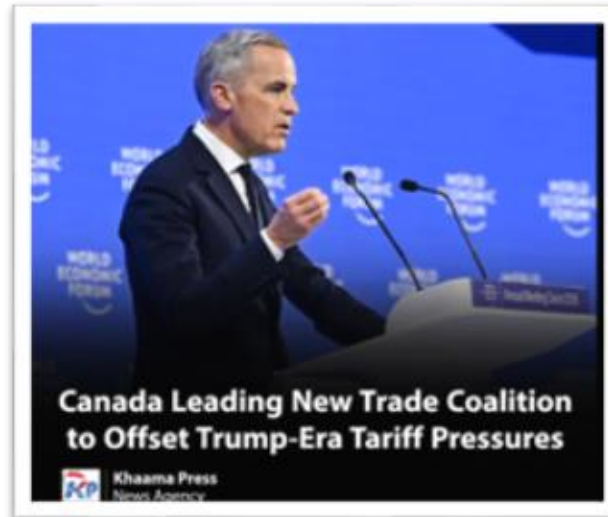
Indian University Bloomington



Changing Global Order



- Anti-globalism
- Weaponize Tariffs



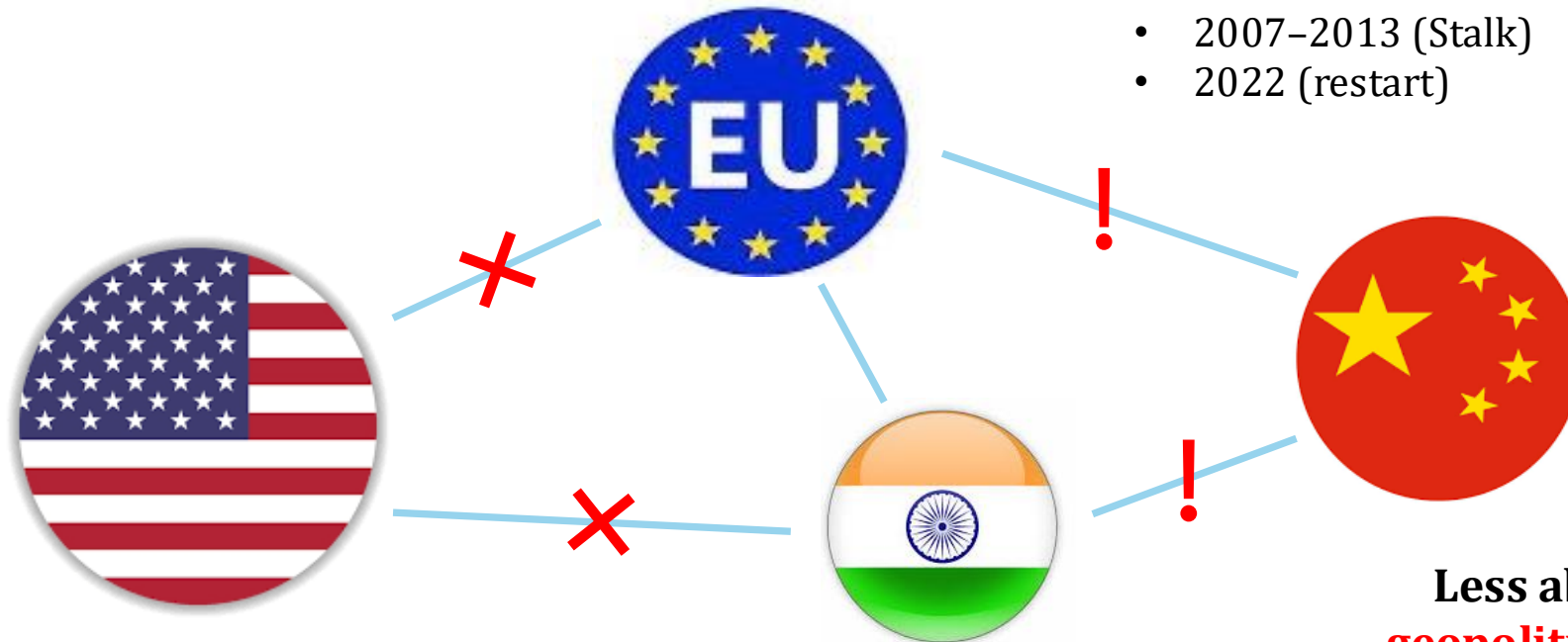
- Rupture of Neo-liberalism Order
- Middle Power: Variable geometry diplomacy



- 2001, 2014, 2026
- Asia-Pacific agenda-setting



India-EU Trade Pact (2026)



Less about economics but
geopolitics network dynamics



It's Not Just About People — It's Also About **Structural Change**



Network Rupture



Network Reconfiguration



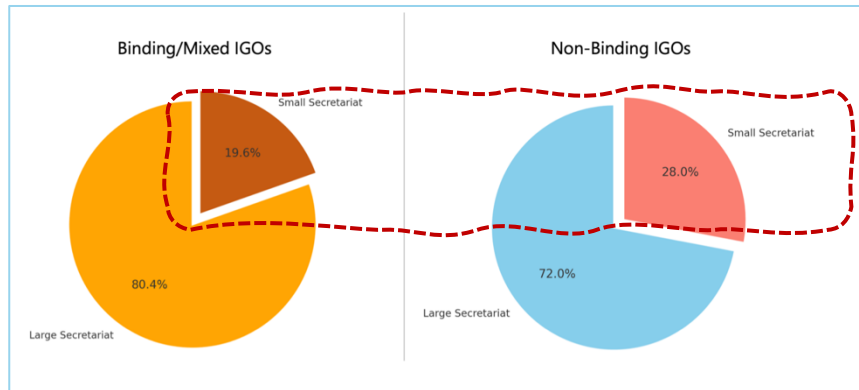
Network Reinforcement

External Shocks on IO Governance

Debre and Dijkstra (2021):

- Many IOs in **Survival Mode** (Anti-globalism, US-China trade war, etc)
- **Larger bureaucracies (50+ staff)**, more resilient

- Non-binding IGOs tend to have smaller bureaucracies



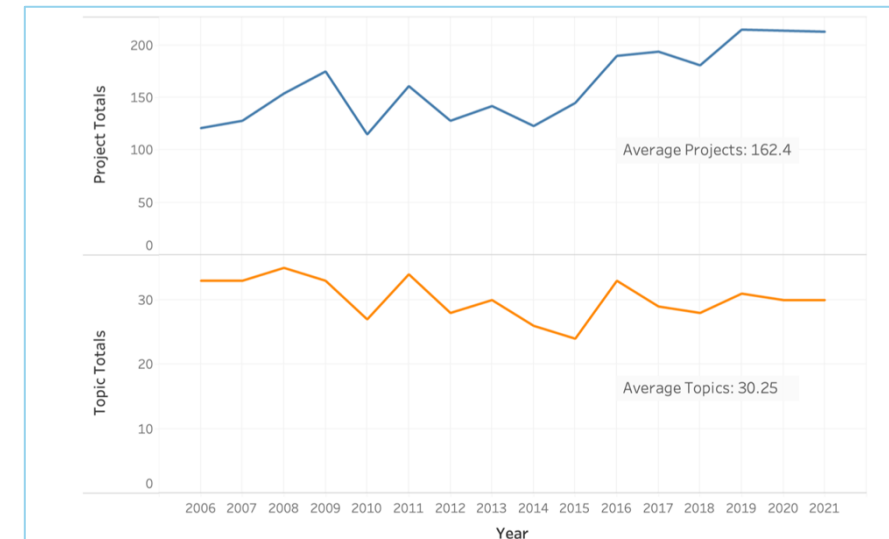
- Soft-law governance weakness: Ambiguous and low-level consensus (Hsieh 2021:217)

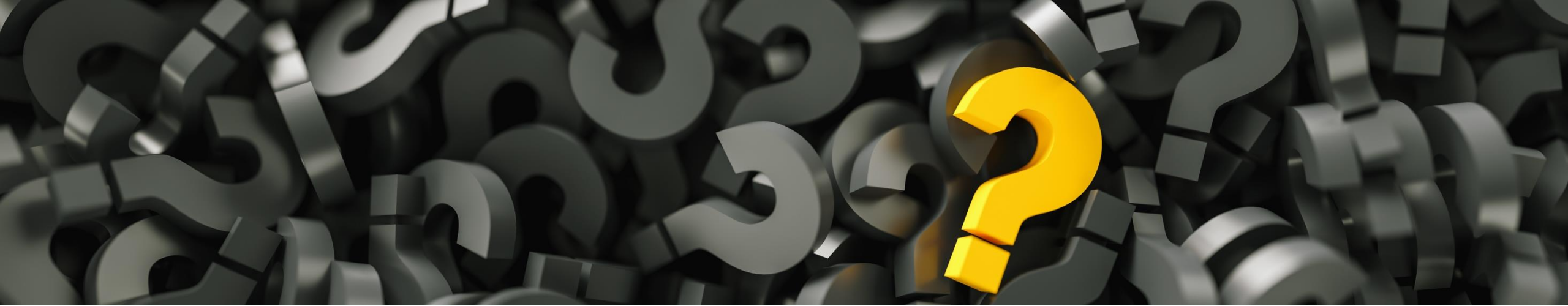
**Non-binding IGO
Less Effective?**

- Participation declining?
- Policy output decreasing?



- 2026
- 2014: BRI & AIIB





Why Non-Binding IGOs Function Effectively under External Shocks?





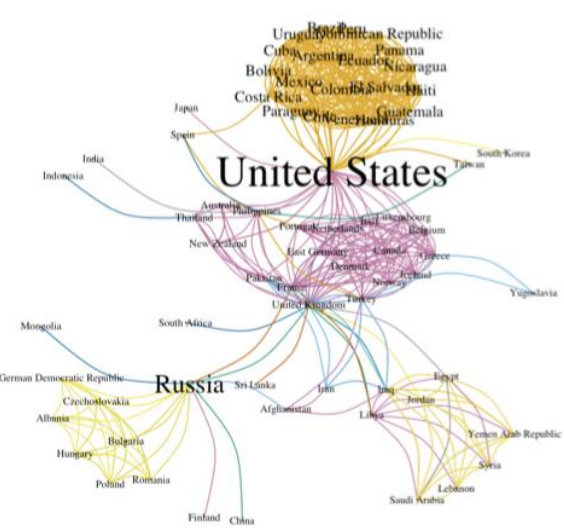
APEC is not just a platform for policy experiment



Networked Strategic Alignments (Connection, Clustering, and Centralization)

Strategy	Logic	Behavioral Pattern	Network Signature
Bandwagoning	Align with dominant power	Hierarchical attachment	Sparse, highly centralized
Balancing	Counter dominant power	Coalition-building	Clustered, moderate centralized
Hedging	Diversify partnerships	Flexible engagement	Dense, decentralization

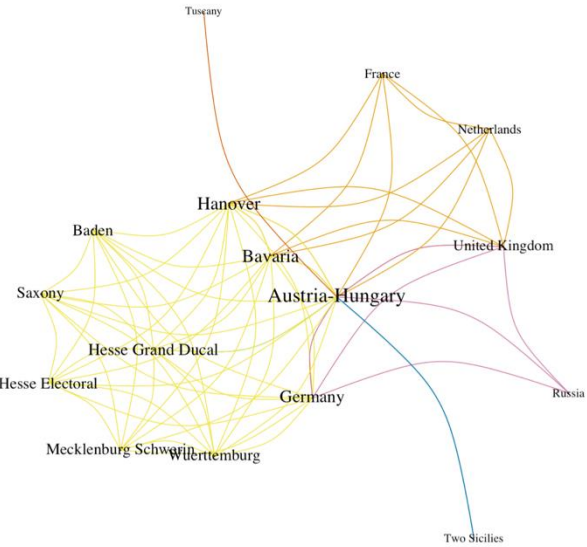
Cold War Alliance 1955



Nodes: 70 | Ties: 727 | Density: 0.301 | Clustering: 0.882 | Centralization: 0.705

Bandwagoning

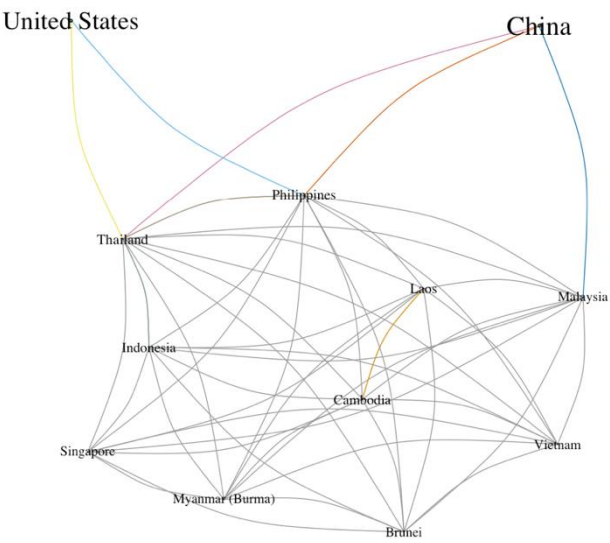
Concert of Europe 1815



Nodes: 16 | Ties: 70 | Density: 0.583 | Clustering: 0.879 | Centralization: 0.508

Balancing

ASEAN Treaty Network 1991-2001



Nodes: 12 | Ties: 53 | Density: 0.803 | Clustering: 0.939 | Centralization: 0.274

Hedging

APEC Co-Sponsorship Data

- Co-Sponsorship Data from 2006 – 2019
- Trade, Energy, HR, and Small and Medium Enterprise (SME)

APEC Project Database

Welcome to the APEC Project Database (PDB)

This database provides access to detailed information on over 3000 projects involving APEC's 21 member economies. The database includes projects from 2006 onwards. Completion Reports and other documents may be found under the "Supporting Documents" tab.

BASIC SEARCH **ADVANCED SEARCH**

Project Title:

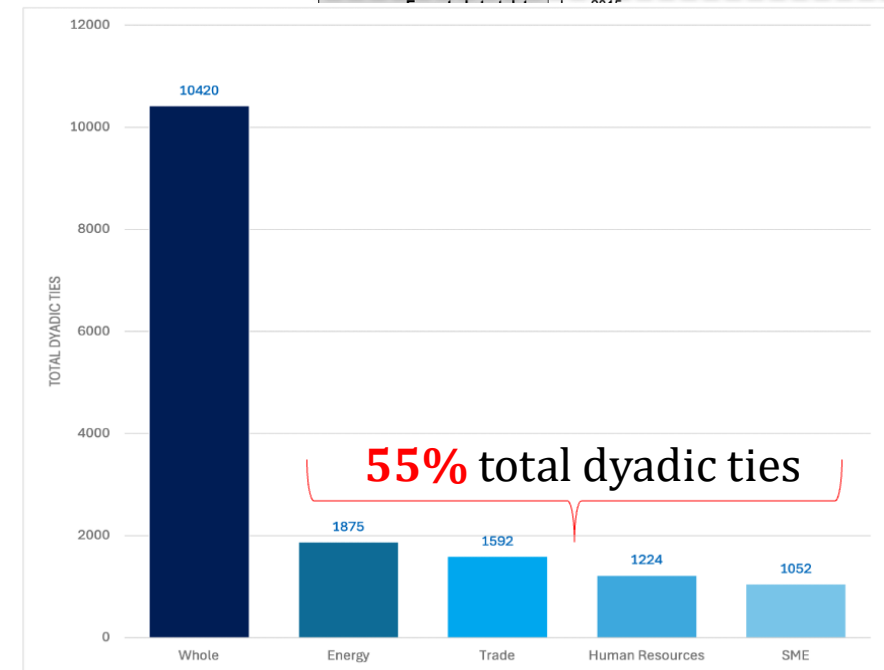
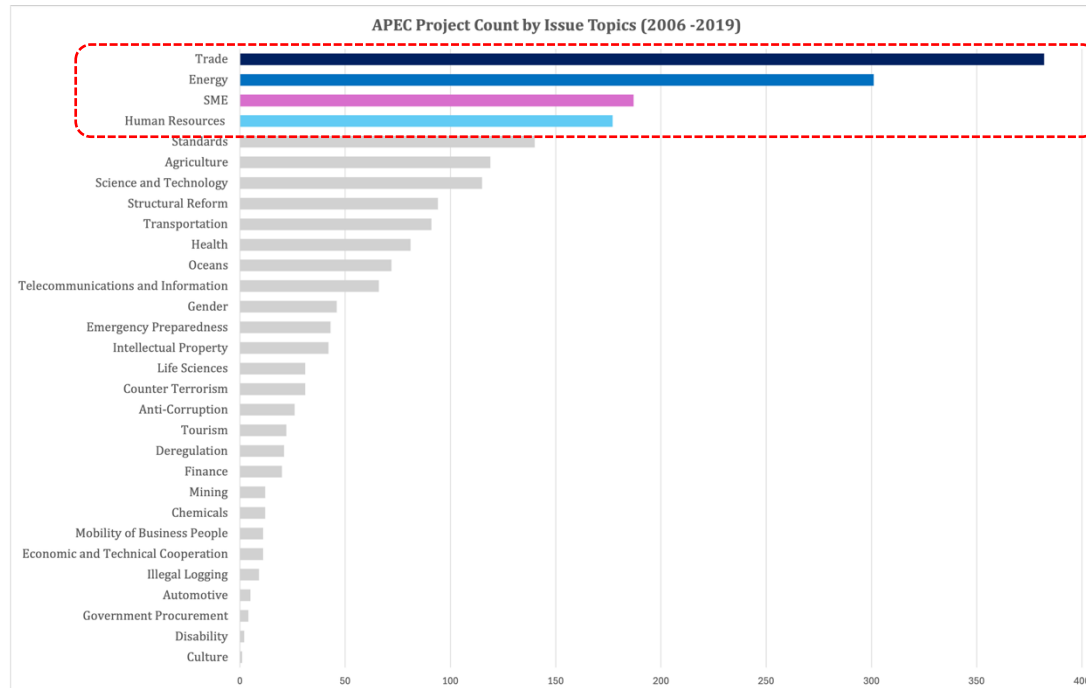
Project title and number: APEC SME Finance Forum [SME 03 2015]

Source of funds (Select one): ☒ X General Project Account ☐ TILF Special Account ☐ APEC Support Fund

APEC forum: APEC SME Working Group

Proposing APEC economy: Philippines

Co-sponsoring economies: Brunei Darussalam, Indonesia, Japan, Korea, Malaysia, Mexico, Papua New Guinea, Peru, Chinese Taipei, Singapore, Thailand, USA, Viet Nam



APEC: Strategic Bandwagoning

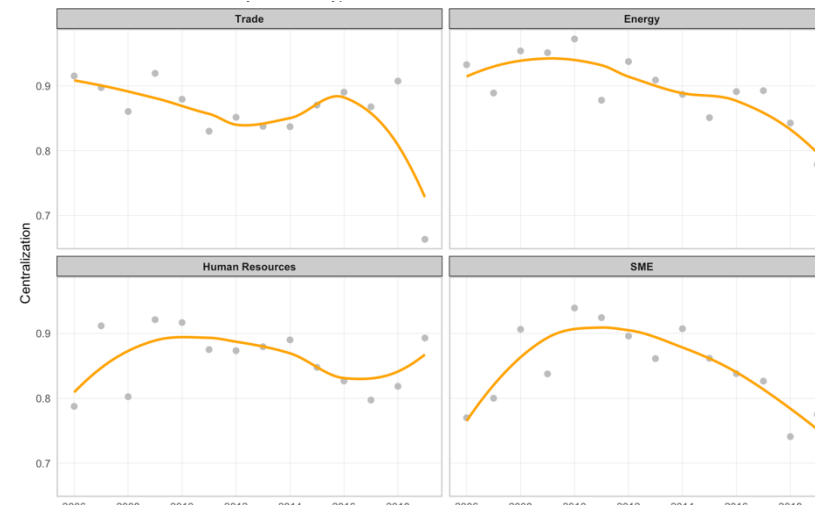
Strategy	Density	Clustering	Centralization
Bandwagoning	↓	↑/→	↑
Balancing	→	↑	→
Hedging	↑	↑/→	↓

Note: ↑ = high, → = moderate, ↓ = low.

Low Density & Moderate Clustering



High Centralization



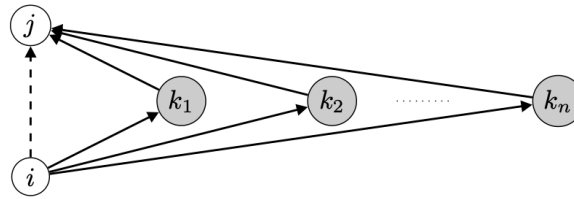
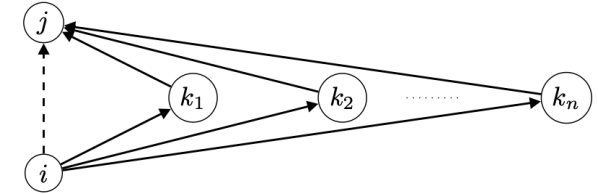
APEC Trade Cooperation (2014)



Density: 0.145 | Clustering: 0.682 | In-strength centralization: 0.837

Clustering and Bandwagoning Alignment:

- **Brokerage Effects:** Friend-of-Friend (FoF) Clustering
- **Power Conditioning Bandwagoning :** FoF Conditioned on Shared Partner's Power



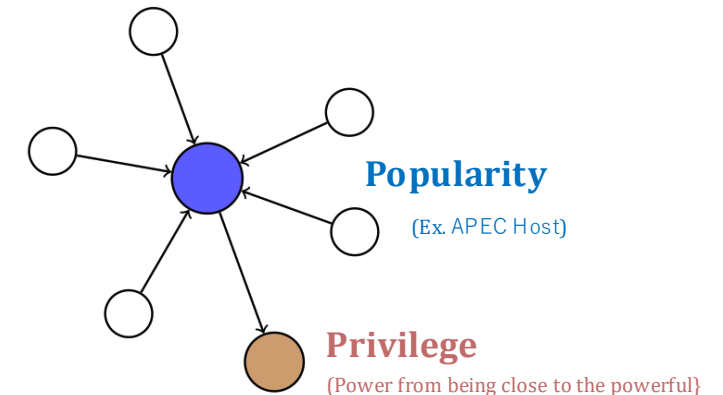
Hard Power



Institutional Power

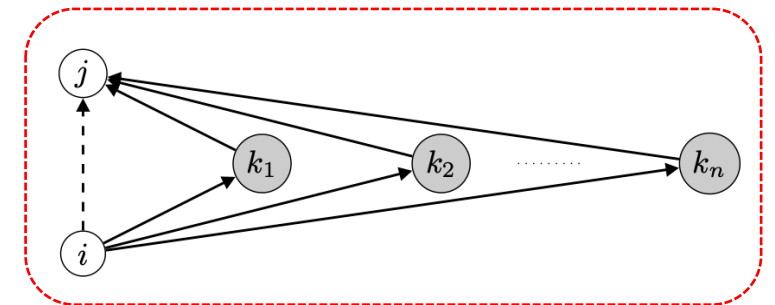
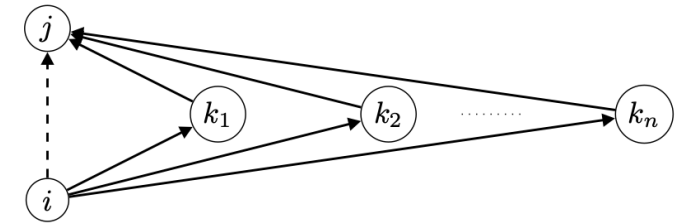
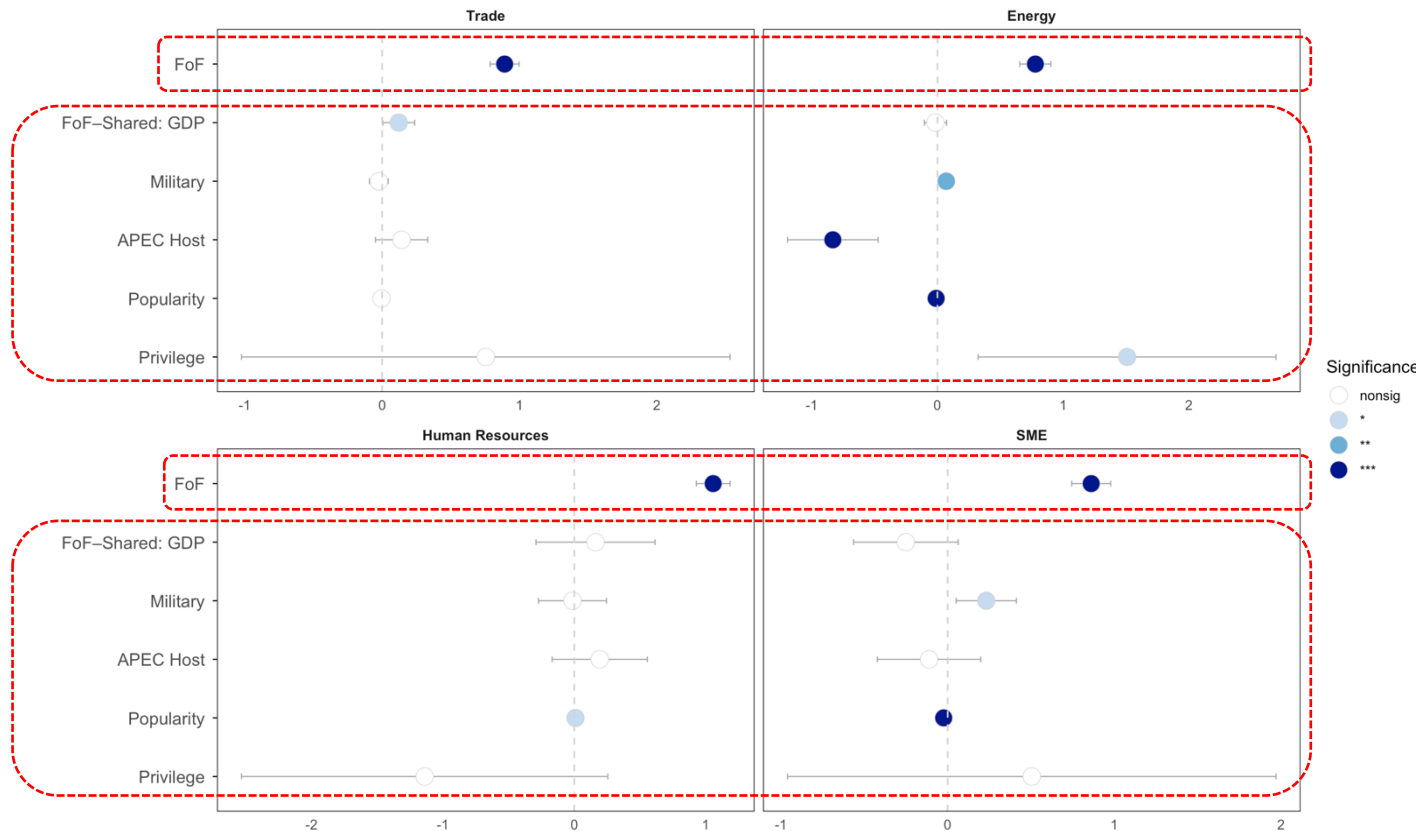


Network Centrality Power



Network Modeling Findings: Cooperation Emerges from the “Right” Clusters

- ❑ Brokerage effects drives the APEC co-sponsorship network
- ❑ Power-conditioned Bandwagoning clustering vary across issue areas



Temporal Exponential Random Graph Modeling (TERGM)

$$\Pr(Y^1, \dots, Y^T) = \prod_{t=1}^T \frac{1}{\kappa_t} \exp \left\{ \sum_A \eta_A g_A(Y^t, Y^{t-1}) \right\}$$

Summary

Insights from Network Analysis

- ❑ APEC is not just a platform for open dialogue
- ❑ Agenda setting emerges through strategic network cooperation
- ❑ Clustering and banwagoning shape strategic alignments



Implications for Existing Views

- Technical cooperation and policy coordination
- Strategic cooperation networks building for member states
 - USA: **Network Rupturing**
 - China: **Network Reinforcement**
 - Middle Powers: **Network Reconfiguration**

**Nonbinding IGOs (flexibility & strategic issue alliance)
will play a larger role in geopolitics**

